Mastering AI Agents

A Beginner's Guide to AGENTS.md and SKILL.md

How to control AI behavior with plain English rules and recipes.

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The Problem: AI Amnesia



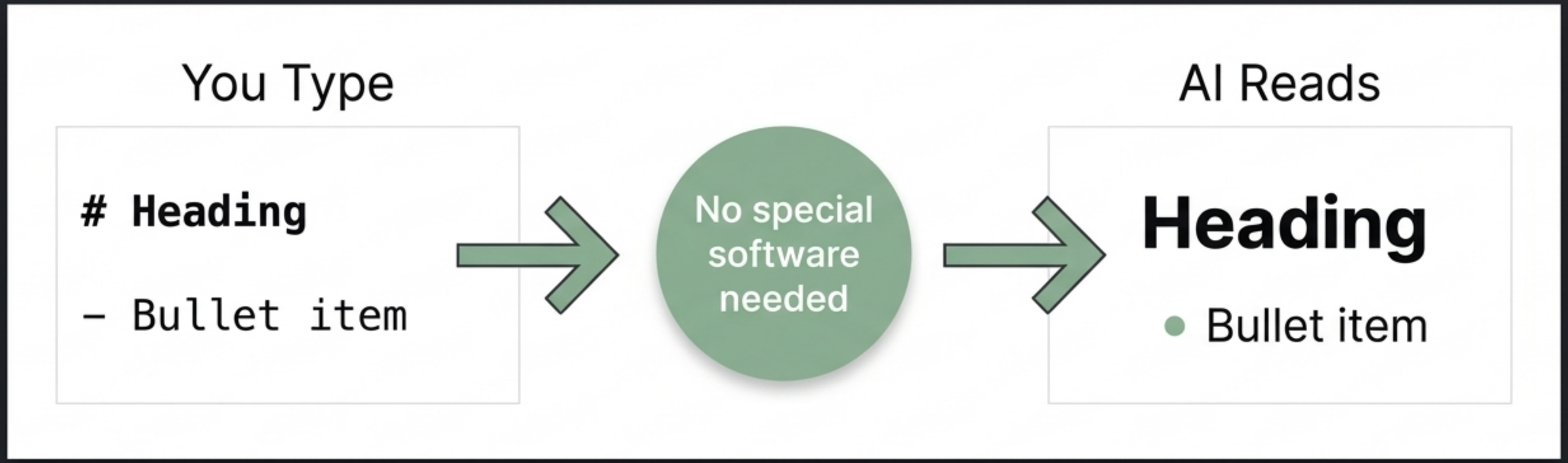
Every new chat is a blank slate.
The AI doesn't know your company,
your style, or your rules.



Unless you write it down.

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The Universal Language: Markdown (.md)



Markdown is just plain text. It is the easiest format for both humans and AI to read perfectly.

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The Ecosystem of Instructions



README.md

Target: Humans

Explains what the project is and how to use it.



AGENTS.md

Target: AI (Global Level)

The permanent House Rules read every single session.



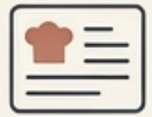
SKILL.md

Target: AI (Local Level)

The specific step-by-step recipes for individual jobs.

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The Core Difference: Rules vs. Recipes

	AGENTS.md 	SKILL.md 
Metaphor	The House Rules	The Cookbook
When is it read?	Every single time you open a chat	Only when a specific task is triggered
What goes inside?	Broad conventions, style guides, core values	Step-by-step procedures, templates, specific formats
Example	Always write in simple English	How to generate the Monthly Sales Report

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Designing Your House Rules

Pack **AGENTS.md** with non-derivable facts the AI cannot guess.



Communication Style

```
This is the Bright Bakery project. Never change
the prices. Check spelling before finishing.
```

Working Conventions

```
Always use Test-Driven Development (TDD).
Write the test before writing the code.
```

Product Invariants

```
Gates fail open: If a user prompt fails, do not
crash the app, just log the error.
```

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Keep the AI’s Backpack Light



Heavy Context Load: Token costs increase by 20% and task success rates plummet.



Light Context Load: The AI moves fast and stays focused.

AGENTS.md is loaded into every single message.
Do not weigh the AI down with things it can figure out itself.

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SKILL.md: The On-Demand Cookbook



1. AI scans the Contents Page (Skill descriptions).

2. When a job comes up, it pulls only that specific recipe.

3. The AI stays focused and doesn't mix up instructions.

Why not put everything in **AGENTS.md**?
Rules are for every task, but steps are only for one.

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Anatomy of a Perfect Skill



1. The Trigger

The short description that tells the AI when to use this file.

`Use this when asked for a status update.`



2. The Steps

The exact, linear procedure to get the job done.



3. The Reference

External templates or glossaries needed to complete the steps.

Keep the main `skill.md` file as small as possible.

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Steering with Leading Words



Instead of writing an essay to explain what you want, use **Leading Words**.

- Short phrases pack massive meaning.
- Triggers the AI's prior knowledge.
- The AI repeats the word in its thinking traces, anchoring its behavior.

Instead of:

Don't do all the database work at once, build a little bit of everything...

Use:

Build a Vertical Slice.

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Real-World Example: The Monthly Sales Report



The Problem

Every month, you need a sales report. Without instructions, the AI hallucinates the format, forgets last month's numbers, and writes the summary in a different tone.



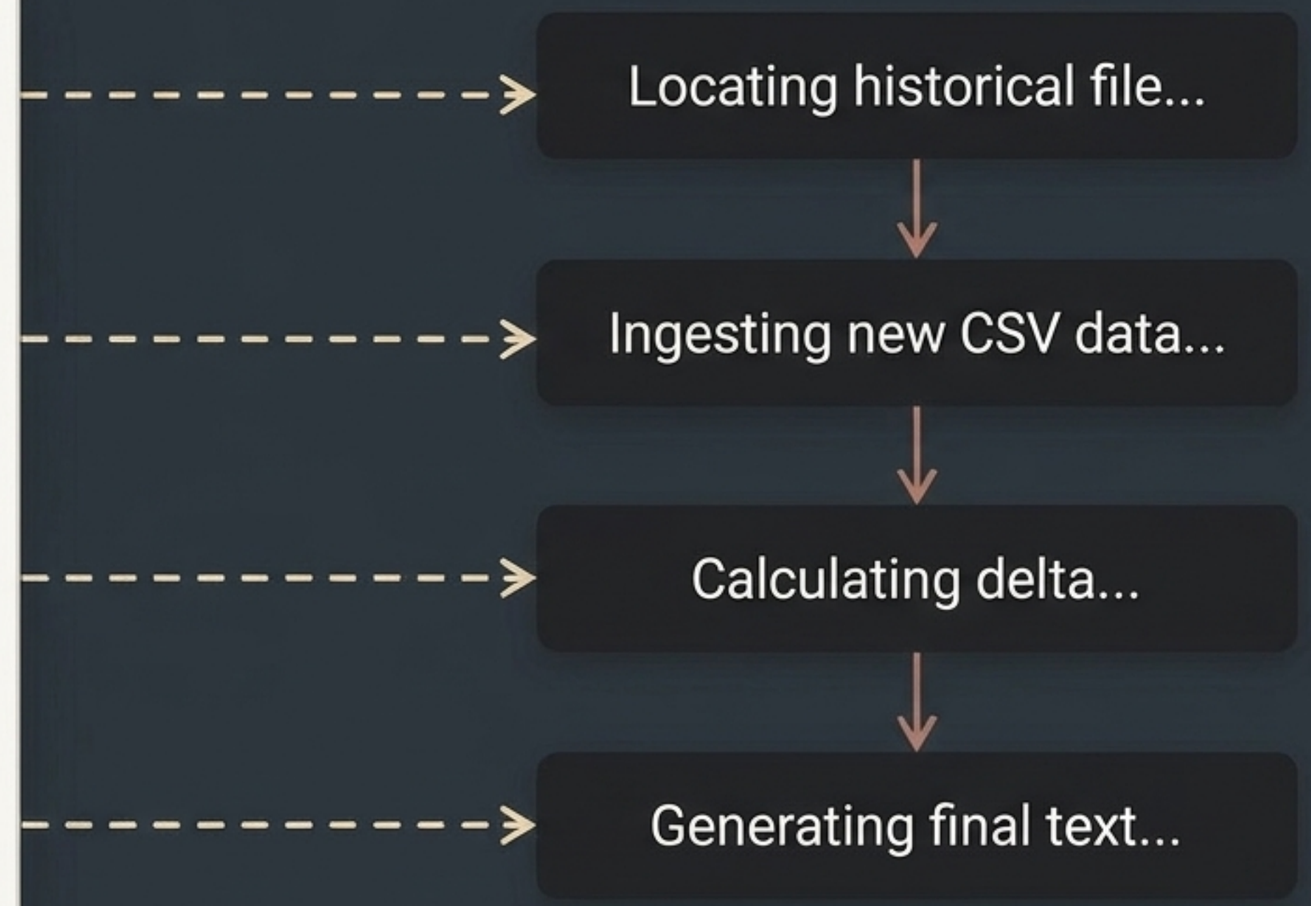
The Goal

Build a `monthly_report_skill.md` that guarantees perfect, repeatable execution.

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Building the Skill: Step-by-Step

1. Open last month's report.
2. Add this month's fresh sales data.
3. Compare the numbers to calculate growth.
4. Write a short summary.



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Attaching the Reference Material

monthly_report_skill.md

Write a short summary using the format in `report_template.md`



Keep the main skill file small. Use a context pointer to direct the AI to a separate template only when it is needed.

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The Golden Rules of Pruning



1. Delete No-ops

If you delete an instruction and the AI's behavior doesn't change, delete the instruction permanently.



2. Clear Out Sediment

As multiple people add to a file, old rules pile up. Audit your files regularly to kill stale or irrelevant material.



3. Don't Repeat Yourself (DRY)

Keep a single source of truth. Don't put the same rule in both `AGENTS.md` and `SKILL.md`.

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You Are the Pilot

- Use **AGENTS.md** to establish the enduring laws of your workspace.
- Use **SKILL.md** to write the precise recipes for your daily tasks.

Stop hoping the AI gets it right. Start writing the blueprint.

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